

Weight-Loss Medications — Wegovy and Contrave

Part 1 — Wegovy (semaglutide)

Purpose of Treatment

Wegovy is used to promote weight loss by decreasing appetite, increasing the feeling of fullness (satiety), and slowing stomach emptying.

Nature of Treatment and Cost

Treatment is generally chronic (long-term) in order to maintain the weight-related benefits.

The average cost without insurance is approximately \$450 per month.

Generic versions have been available since the summer of 2026, which may reduce costs.

Common (Expected) Side Effects

These effects are generally transient and occur mainly at the beginning of treatment or when the dose is increased.

Digestive:

- Nausea: 16–20%
- Diarrhea: 10%
- Vomiting: 5–9%
- Abdominal pain: 6–11%
- Constipation: 3–6%
- Bloating: 2–3%
- Gas: 1–2%
- Reflux: 2%
- Dyspepsia (indigestion): 3–4%

Other:

- Increased lipase: 22–34% (usually of no consequence)
- Hypoglycemia: 2–4% (mainly if you are on diabetes treatment)
- Fatigue / dizziness: 0–1%
- Injection site reaction: 0–1%

Tips to Improve Tolerance

- Eat slowly and in small amounts
- Avoid fatty meals at the beginning of treatment
- Follow the gradual dose escalation schedule
- Maintain good hydration

Rare but Important Side Effects

Pancreatitis: a rare but potentially serious complication

Pancreatitis is a rare side effect of Wegovy, but it is important to know that, in some cases, it can lead to serious complications.

- In approximately 80% of cases, pancreatitis is mild and resolves without lasting effects.
- However, in 10 to 20% of cases, it can become more severe.

Notable complications:

- Severe infection (sepsis): approximately 5 to 10% of cases — requires hospitalization
- Risk of death: approximately 2 to 5% overall, but up to 20 to 30% in severe forms

Gallstones (~2%)

Associated with rapid weight loss. Pain under the ribs on the right side after meals.

Retinopathy (in patients with diabetes)

May occur if blood sugar improves rapidly. Watch for visual symptoms.

Thyroid cancer (very rare, not demonstrated in humans)

A signal observed in animal studies. Avoid if you have a personal or family history of medullary thyroid carcinoma or MEN2 syndrome.

When to Seek Prompt Medical Attention

- Severe, persistent abdominal pain
- Significant vomiting or dehydration
- Visual disturbances
- A lump in the neck or difficulty swallowing

Recommended Follow-Up

Regular medical follow-up is necessary to adjust the dose, monitor tolerance, and evaluate the benefits of treatment.

Part 2 — Contrave (naltrexone/bupropion)

Purpose of Treatment

Contrave combines two medications (naltrexone and bupropion) that work together on the brain's hunger and reward centers. It decreases appetite and helps control cravings and "emotional" eating. It is used as an addition to — not a replacement for — a reduced-calorie diet and increased physical activity, for long-term weight management.

Nature of Treatment and Cost

Treatment is generally chronic (long-term) in order to maintain the weight-related benefits. It comes as tablets (no injection).

- Cost without insurance: approximately \$280 to \$450 per month depending on the pharmacy (most often \$320 to \$380).
- Not covered by RAMQ or public plans; most private insurance plans cover it — check with your insurer.
- No generic version is currently available. In some cases, your physician may discuss less expensive alternatives.

Expected Effectiveness

Contrave produces **modest** weight loss. In studies, the additional weight loss attributable to the medication is about 4 to 5% of initial body weight after one year, and about one in two patients loses at least 5% of their weight. Results are considerably better when the medication is combined with sustained dietary and behavioral support (up to ~9% loss). In people with diabetes, weight loss is about 5%, with a slight improvement in blood sugar control.

Contrave is less powerful than injectable GLP-1 medications (e.g., Wegovy). On the other hand, it is taken as tablets and costs less than most other weight-loss medications.

If weight loss is less than 5% after about 16 weeks of treatment (including 12 weeks at the full dose), stopping the medication is recommended, as the chances of meaningful benefit are then low.

Common Side Effects

NB: the medication monograph contains the complete list. The effects below are the most common (percentages observed with Contrave in studies):

- Nausea: ~33% (the most common effect) • Constipation: ~19% • Headaches: ~18%
- Vomiting: ~11% • Dizziness: ~10% • Insomnia: ~9% • Dry mouth: ~8%

These effects occur mainly at the beginning of treatment and with dose increases, then often improve over time. In studies, about 1 in 4 patients stopped the medication because of side effects — don't hesitate to consult before stopping; slowing the titration often helps.

Tips to Improve Tolerance

- Follow the gradual dose escalation, without skipping ahead
- Take the tablets with a snack or a light meal (never a fatty meal)
- Stay well hydrated; increase fiber if constipated

Important Warnings

- **Opioids:** naltrexone blocks the effect of opioids. Opioid painkillers (morphine, codeine, oxycodone, etc.) will be **ineffective** during treatment, and using them can be dangerous. Tell any physician or dentist that you take Contrave, including before surgery or in an emergency.
- **Seizures:** bupropion lowers the seizure threshold (rare risk at usual doses).
- **Blood pressure and heart rate:** a slight increase is possible. Blood pressure monitoring is recommended at the start of treatment, then regularly (for example at the pharmacy).
- **Liver:** seek care if your skin turns yellow, if your urine is dark, or in case of significant pain on the right side of the abdomen.
- **Mood and suicidal thoughts:** bupropion (an antidepressant) can, rarely, cause mood changes, agitation, or suicidal thoughts, mainly in young adults early in treatment.

Contraindications — Tell Your Physician If You Have:

- Uncontrolled high blood pressure • Epilepsy or a history of seizures
- Anorexia or bulimia (current or past) • Recent withdrawal from alcohol, benzodiazepines, or antiseizure medications
- Opioid use (painkillers, methadone, etc.) • An MAOI taken within the last 14 days
- Pregnancy or breastfeeding • Another medication containing bupropion (Wellbutrin, Zyban) — do not combine

For Whom Might This Medication Be a Good Choice?

Contrave may be particularly interesting if you have concurrent depression, if you want to quit smoking (bupropion helps with smoking cessation), or if your weight difficulties are mainly related to cravings and emotional eating. Caution is advised after age 65 (increased sensitivity to nervous system effects). To consider: treatment requires 4 tablets per day.

When to Seek Prompt Medical Attention

- Unusual change in mood or behavior (noticed by you or your loved ones), agitation, or dark thoughts — seek care without delay
- Seizure
- Allergic reaction (facial swelling, hives, difficulty breathing)
- Severe headache with very high blood pressure, chest pain, or sustained palpitations
- Yellow skin or significant abdominal pain

Recommended Follow-Up

Regular medical follow-up is necessary: blood pressure monitoring, evaluation of weight loss and tolerance, and reassessment of whether treatment remains appropriate at around 16 weeks, then periodically.